

Meridian State University

Student Code of Conduct

Community Standards, Conduct Process, and Sanctions

Document Code: SCC-POL-520

Effective Date: August 1, 2026

Issuing Office: Office of the Registrar & Academic Affairs

Review Cycle: Annual

1. Purpose and Authority

The Student Code of Conduct ("the Code") establishes standards of behavior expected of all students at Meridian State University, both on campus and in University-affiliated activities off campus, including online conduct that materially disrupts the University's operations or endangers the safety of its community. The Code is administered by the Office of Student Conduct under the authority of the Vice President for Student Affairs.

2. Jurisdiction

The Code applies to conduct that occurs on University premises, at University-sponsored events, during study-abroad or internship placements, and, where the conduct threatens the safety or integrity of the campus community, off campus. Jurisdiction is not limited by academic term and may extend to conduct discovered after a student has graduated where a degree was obtained through misconduct.

3. Prohibited Conduct

- Physical harm or threats of harm to any member of the University community.
- Harassment, including conduct based on a protected characteristic that creates a hostile environment.
- Hazing, defined as any action that endangers the physical or psychological well-being of a person for purposes of initiation into or affiliation with an organization.
- Unauthorized possession of weapons on University property.
- Alcohol and drug violations, including underage possession, distribution, and operating a vehicle under the influence on campus.
- Damage to or theft of University or personal property.
- Unauthorized entry or use of University facilities, including computing systems.
- Disruption of University operations, including teaching, research, administration, or public events.

4. Student Conduct Process

4.1 Initial Review

Reports of misconduct are submitted through the online Incident Report form or directly to the Office of Student Conduct. A conduct officer conducts an initial review within 5 business days to determine whether the matter proceeds to a formal resolution process.

4.2 Resolution Pathways

- Administrative Resolution — an informal meeting between the student and a conduct officer, used for lower-level violations, resulting in a written resolution agreement.
- Formal Hearing — used for violations that could result in suspension or dismissal, conducted before a Student Conduct Board comprising faculty, staff, and student members.
- Alternative Resolution — restorative justice conferencing, available for eligible cases with mutual agreement of all parties.

4.3 Standard of Evidence

Determinations of responsibility are made using the preponderance of the evidence standard — that is, whether it is more likely than not that a violation occurred.

5. Sanctions

Sanction	Description
Warning	Formal notice that continued misconduct may result in further action.
Disciplinary Probation	A defined period during which further violations carry escalated consequences.
Restitution	Repayment for damage, loss, or injury caused.
Educational Sanction	Required workshop, reflective essay, or community service.
Suspension	Temporary separation from the University for a specified period.
Dismissal	Permanent separation from the University.

6. Interim Measures

In cases involving an ongoing threat to safety, the Dean of Students may impose interim measures, including interim suspension, no-contact directives, or housing relocation, pending the outcome of the conduct process. Interim measures are not punitive and are reviewed within 5 business days at the student's request.

7. Student Rights in the Conduct Process

- The right to receive written notice of the alleged violation prior to any meeting or hearing.
- The right to review the evidence supporting the allegation with reasonable advance notice.
- The right to present witnesses and evidence on their own behalf.
- The right to be accompanied by an advisor of their choosing throughout the process.
- The right to a decision based solely on the evidence presented, free from bias or conflict of interest.
- The right to appeal a Formal Hearing decision as described in Section 7.

These rights apply equally to any other party involved in the incident, including a reporting student, consistent with the University's commitment to a fair and balanced process for all participants.

8. Appeals

A student may appeal a Formal Hearing decision to the Appellate Board within 10 business days on the grounds of procedural irregularity, new evidence, or a sanction disproportionate to the violation. Administrative Resolutions are not eligible for appeal, as they require the student's voluntary agreement to the outcome.

9. Frequently Asked Questions

Does the Code apply to conduct on social media?

The Code applies to online conduct, including social media, when it materially disrupts University operations, targets a member of the community with harassment or threats, or otherwise falls within the jurisdiction described in Section 2.

Will my parents be notified if I am found responsible for a violation?

Parental notification is governed separately by FERPA and applicable state law; in general, notification may occur for alcohol or drug violations involving students under 21, consistent with federal guidelines.

Can I bring a lawyer to a Formal Hearing?

Students may be accompanied by an advisor, including an attorney, at their own expense; however, the advisor's role is limited to consultation and does not include direct participation in questioning.

10. Related Policies and Resources

This policy should be read in conjunction with other governing University policies, including the University Catalog, the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) Notice, and any college- or department-specific handbooks that supplement, but do not contradict, the standards set out here. Where a conflict exists between this policy and a college-level document, this policy governs unless an explicit written exception has been approved by the Provost's Office.

- University Catalog (undergraduate and graduate editions), published annually
- FERPA Notice of Student Rights, available through the Office of the Registrar
- Student Handbook, distributed at orientation and available online
- College- and department-specific supplemental guidelines, where applicable

11. Contact and Further Assistance

Questions regarding the interpretation or application of this policy should be directed to the Office of Student Conduct. Students are encouraged to reach out early in the process, as many concerns can be resolved informally before they require a formal procedure.

Contact Point	Detail
Office	Office of Student Conduct
Email	studentconduct@meridianstate.edu
Phone	(555) 201-4440
Office Hours	Monday–Friday, 8:30 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.
Walk-in Location	Student Services Building, Suite 200

12. Policy Revision History

Version	Date	Summary of Changes
1.0	August 2021	Initial policy adopted by the Board of Trustees.
1.1	August 2023	Clarified procedural timelines and appeal deadlines.
2.0	August 2025	Comprehensive revision to align with updated accreditation standards.
2.1	August 2026	Minor updates for the current academic year; see effective date above.

Note: This document supersedes all prior versions upon its effective date. Archived versions are available upon request from the issuing office.